

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: SOUTHERN ARKANSAS UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: April 2–5, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
EXCEEDS	MEETS	MEETS
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Southern Arkansas University
LOCATION	Magnolia, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Educator preparation program, literacy
PATHWAY	Traditional and Alternative
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2023)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	April 2-5, 2024

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
EXCEEDS 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	<i>Not individually rated</i>
Concepts of print instruction	<i>Not individually rated</i>
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Meets
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	<i>Not individually rated</i>
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Exceeds
Fluency instruction	<i>Not individually rated</i>
Vocabulary instruction	<i>Not individually rated</i>
Text comprehension instruction	<i>Not individually rated</i>
Writing instruction	<i>Not individually rated</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers rated the quality of literacy coursework Exceeds. They identified deep science-of-reading content, repeated opportunities to observe, practice, and apply evidence-based strategies, and meaningful use of high-quality instructional materials as strengths. The 2023 report discussed all nine criteria but stated a standalone criterion-level rating for only oral language instruction (Meets) and phonics, orthography, and automatic word recognition instruction (Exceeds). The remaining criteria are therefore marked Not individually rated rather than assigned a rating that does not appear in the source report.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Strengthen oral language coursework by adding practice with language structures, engaging conversation, and additional models and instructional strategies that connect content to application. • Strengthen scaffolding for multilingual learners at different language and literacy levels to support accurate and fluent reading, comprehension, and writing development.	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Meets
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Exceeds
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Exceeds
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Exceeds
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Meets
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Meets
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Meets
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Meets
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Meets
Quality of written and oral feedback	Meets
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Of the eleven criteria in this area, eight were rated Meets and three were rated Exceeds. Mentor teacher selection, opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice, and placement access to high-quality instructional materials were the highest-rated criteria.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Ensure that all candidates, regardless of pathway, receive consistent, intensive feedback, training, and coaching, including candidates in nonresidency experiences. • Expand the current pre-conference, observation, and post-conference cycle to include co-observations with site coordinators and mentor teachers at initial, midterm, and final evaluations. • Use co-observations to calibrate observers and strengthen the accuracy and usefulness of oral and written feedback across candidate experiences.	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Meets
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Exceeds
Quality of monitoring	Meets
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Meets
Quality improvement planning	Exceeds
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Exceeds
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Of the seven criteria in this area, four were rated Meets and three were rated Exceeds. Internal quality control gates, quality improvement planning, and partnerships supporting candidate experience with high-quality instructional materials were the highest-rated criteria.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
- Enhance the monitoring system to strengthen connections between program coursework and the clinical component. - Share observation and feedback data with mentor teachers so they understand how candidates are applying coursework knowledge and can support development in key areas.	

Source: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, Southern Arkansas University, April 2-5, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2023). Ratings are transcribed from the review report. "Not individually rated" means the report discussed the criterion but did not state a standalone criterion-level rating.